

RUNNER BEANS *Phaseolus coccineus*

Attractive and easy to grow, runner beans are used by gardeners in the US mainly for ornamental purposes. In Europe, however, they are a delicious garden staple. Most varieties will grow very tall and add structure and interest to your garden. They will also produce an abundance of beautiful red, white, or bi-colored flowers. Dwarf varieties are also available, and beans can be found in a range of colors.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW/PLANT				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Site your runner beans carefully: most will grow fairly tall and can become top-heavy, so give them plenty of support and a sheltered location to protect them from strong winds. They thrive in deep, fertile soil, so dig in some well-rotted manure or compost in the fall before planting the following spring. Also, be sure not to plant them where peas or beans have grown in the last two years.

Sow seed in mid-spring for a midsummer crop, or sow in midsummer for an fall crop. If the weather is cold, warm up the soil with a cold frame or cloche. Construct the supports for your beans; use bamboo canes to create teepees or double rows of supports, and sow seed



Train bean seedlings up bamboo supports.

at a depth of 2 in (5 cm) at the base of each cane. Seed can be sown under cover before planting out, but bear in mind that roots will grow deep, so use long paper "tube pots" that can be planted straight into the ground.

CROP CARE

Train the young seedlings around the canes, tying them in with string if necessary. Once plants